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Title:

Dis-Orientation

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Dis-Orientation
By Robert W. LaVohn

Taylor, a nervous college freshman, stands before a judge.

Taylor: How do I…plead? I plead with great humility, Your Honor, and I may even cry a little!

(a pause)

Oh, to the charges. How do I plead to the charges? I plead not. I mean, I do plead, but I plead not guilty. Well, actually, I am, technically, guilty of the "destruction of property" part, but the public intoxication is entirely a misunderstanding. I was wearing the champagne, not drinking it. And I did not actually assault the officer, either, but I can understand how he might have gotten that idea.

(a pause)

Yes! Absolutely, I can indeed start at the beginning. I have wanted to be a student at Podunkwa University ever since I was little. My dad would take me to all the football games in the fall and–

(a pause)

Right. The beginning of this particular event. If it's okay, I do have to go back a *little* farther to the beginning of Orientation Week. See, when the freshmen arrive on campus, they put us in small groups so we can get to know some of the other freshmen better. Build relationships, strengthen community–that sort of thing. I was in a group with Jade and Tim and Murphy and Celia and Marta and Amir, but we call him Little Amir, because one of the guys in charge of the group who's an upperclassman is *also* named Amir, so we call him Big Amir and the freshman Little Amir, and–

(a pause)

Yes, absolutely, I just want to establish the context. So, all of the freshmen groups compete in this *huge* scavenger hunt at the end of the week. It's a really important event, and Big Amir really wanted to win. And Jade and Tim and Murphy and Celia and

Marta and Little Amir and I didn't want to let him down, right? So, that's how we ended up at the wedding at the Cordoba Hotel.

(a pause)

No sir, we were not invited guests.

(a pause)

No, I do not know the DeLisle family.

(a pause)

No sir, I do not know the Monroe family, either. In all honesty, Your Honor, we were completely unaware that a wedding was even taking place there. But you see, sir, one item that was on the scavenger hunt list was a champagne glass from the Cordoba Hotel. That was number seventeen on the list, right between a live catfish and a dozen multicolored golf balls. Now, the golf balls were pretty easy to get from the mini-golf place on highway 43, but the live catfish was a real challenge, and…

(a pause)

No, we couldn't split up–we had to stay together. That was one of the rules. And that's why when we got to the Cordoba, Murphy was still holding the cooler with the live catfish inside.

(a pause)

We were afraid that if we left Sylvester in the car that he might flop around and tip over the cooler and then he might die, and we wouldn't get any points if he died.

(a pause)

No sir, Sylvester wasn't part of the freshman group. That's what we named the catfish–you know, after the cartoon cat? Because he's, well, a catfish. So anyway, we're all standing there in the lobby of the Cordoba Hotel, and Murphy has the cooler with Sylvester inside, and Little Amir has the bag with a dozen multicolored golf balls.

(a pause)

I'm getting to that, sir. I look inside the open doorway of the Western Zephyr Room, and I see a waiter in a tuxedo carrying a whole tray of champagne glasses. And I figure that they aren't going to miss just one, right? So I tell everyone just to stay put while I get item number seventeen! But as I'm heading that way, Sylvester starts flopping around, I mean, just going through all sorts of contortions, and water is splashing out the sides of the cooler and stuff, so I tell Little Amir to help Murphy hold the cooler. And that's when he hands me the bag of golf balls.

(a pause)

Little Amir is not a large person, sir, and frankly he doesn't handle pressure well. So I took the bag of golf balls from him and headed toward the Western Zephyr Room, leaving him with Jade and Tim and Murphy and Celia and Marta and Sylvester.

(a pause)

No sir, I was alone. See, technically, the rules of the competition say as long as you stay within a hundred yards of the group, you're still together. In this case, I knew I had to get the champagne glass by myself. Everyone else was busy with the flopping catfish in the cooler or holding on to the other things on the list or just keeping a lookout.

(a pause)

A lookout. In case something went wrong.

(a pause)

Yes sir. Something did *indeed* go wrong. It went very wrong. The wrongest. As a waiter walked out the door, I slid into the Western Zephyr Room with no problem, and it was at that moment I realized, sir, that the reception for the DeLisle/Monroe Wedding was taking place. I knew that time was of the essence, and I had no intention of causing a disturbance in any way. And so when I saw the champagne glass on the corner of the table, I grabbed it and started to leave.

(a pause)

(a deep sigh, and a hanging head)

No, Your Honor, I was not aware at first that the glass I was taking was part of a champagne tower for the reception. When the entire pyramid of glasses collapsed on top of me, I realized that I had not chosen well.

(a pause)

Well, your honor, I didn't know quite what to do at that point. I was covered in champagne, and surrounded by broken glass, and everyone was shocked and staring at me while I stood there still holding a bag full of multicolored golf balls in one hand and a champagne glass in the other!

(a pause)

It's hard to say, sir, it was pretty chaotic, and the events all kind of ran together. At some point my friends came in–

(a pause)

–yes, they were still carrying Sylvester, who had calmed down a little bit by then. So, they came in, and we were all trying to explain to Mr. DeLisle–

(a pause)

I'm sorry, *Senator* DeLisle–that we would find a way to pay him back for the damages, and it was about that time that Sebastian flopped out of the cooler onto Mrs. Monroe, I think, and she fainted, and–

(a pause)

Yes, the paramedics said she's going to be fine. And it wasn't really Little Amir's fault, I guess. He does not handle pressure well, as I said, and his hands were kind of sweaty, so he couldn't keep the lid on tightly, so when Sylvester started to flop around again, off popped the lid. You really should have seen the look on Mrs. Monroe's face when a five-pound catfish landed on her!

(a pause; looks down)

No sir, it was not funny. And yes, we were concerned about Mrs. Monroe, but we had to act fast to get Sylvester back in the cooler.

(a pause)

Yes, as the police report indicates, we did, in fact, put some of the shrimp from the buffet into his cooler, but that's because Marta said she thought he might be hungry and maybe a snack would settle him down. Anyway, when the police officer that arrived on the scene was trying to take my statement, Sylvester started to flop some more, and I yelled at Little Amir to hold it tighter this time, because we didn't want another Mrs. Monroe episode, but he and Murphy were really struggling, so I started to go help them, but the officer yelled at me to come back because he wasn't finished taking my statement, and so I immediately turned around to do what he asked, because I respect the law greatly, Your Honor. Unfortunately, that's when I slipped on the champagne on the floor and lost my balance, and in trying to maintain my footing, I accidentally hit the officer in the face with the bag of a dozen multicolored golf balls, knocking him out cold.

(a pause)

No, sir. We did *not* win. Even with all the delay caused by the incident, we had acquired every item we needed. Sadly, however, by the time we returned to Podunkwa and opened the cooler, Sylvester had…passed on.

(a pause)

We believe he..well, he choked on the shrimp, sir.

(a pause)

Yes, Your Honor. I recognize that our poor decisions resulted in this unfortunate outcome. A ruined wedding, a traumatized mother of the groom, an unconscious officer of the law, and…(tearfully) and a dead Sylvester. I take full responsibility.

(a pause)

Really? *You* went to Podunkwa too? And so did Senator Delisle? *AND* Mrs. Monroe? Really, what are the odds?

(a pause, during which Taylor's face goes through multiple expressions of concern, surprise, and, finally, elation) ad lib "Uh-huh. Oh! Oh!" etc.

Thank you for understanding, sir. And thank you for dropping the charges. And yes, I have already spoken with Jade and Tim and Murphy and Celia and Marta and Little Amir, and we're going to be fully responsible for the damages.

(a pause)

What's that? My major? I was looking at Veterinary Science, but after my experience with Sylvester, I'm not sure that's a good idea.

(a pause)

My new major? Pre-law.